17. Management of Forts and the Navy

Shivaji Maharaj conquered many enemies to establish his Swaraj. Be it war or governance, his management skill can be seen in all areas. Let us learn about the management skills of Shivaji Maharaj in this lesson.

Do you know?

- What is management skill?

Management skill means working in a disciplined manner, on a task one has undertaken to achieve a definite goal.

The management skills of Shivaji Maharaj are seen at all times in the battles he fought all his life and also in his overall administration. Let us look at a few examples :

Building Forts

Shivaji Maharaj protected his Swaraj with the help of forts. In the book 'Aadnyaapatra' or 'Royal Edict', the importance of forts has been aptly summed up as follows : 'The essence of the whole kingdom is forts'. Shivaji Maharaj had roamed through the Sahyadri ranges in his youth. On countless occasions, he had gazed at the forts situated in the Sahyadri. He had understood the importance of forts in the protection of Swaraj.

Shivaji Maharaj built all three types of forts – forest forts, hill forts and sea forts. A sea fort is also known as 'Janjira'. He employed experts like Hiroji Indulkar and Arjoji Yadav to build many new forts like Rajgad, Pratapgad and Sindhudurg. He repaired some old forts like Vijaydurg, Torana and Rangna and built the new fort of Raigad. He had about 300 forts.

Do you know?

- It is believed that the book 'Aadnyaapatra' was written by Ramchandrapant Amatya at the order of Chhatrapati Rajaram Maharaj, the younger son of Shivaji Maharaj.

You can do this.

- In the Diwali vacation, construct the model of a fort with the help of your friends.
  - List the materials you will need to build the fort.
  - Choose a suitable place.
  - Prepare a blueprint to show the arrangements for houses and water.

Can you tell?

- Name a fort or cave-sculpture in your locality.
- What articles / buildings can be seen on it?
- What type of fort is it?

Building a Fort

Management of Forts

Shivaji Maharaj had made definite arrangements for the protection of forts.

On each fort, the officers Killedar, Sabnis and Karkhanis were appointed. The Sabnis and Karkhanis worked under the Killedar. Their work is shown in the chart below.

Killedar (Havaldar)

- To protect and administer the fort.
- To issue orders to the Sabnis and Karkhanis.
- To follow government orders, instructions and letters.

Sabnis

- To keep accounts (Record income and expenses on the fort).
- To collect revenue / tax from the subjects on the fort and around it.
- To handle the correspondence.

Karkhanis

- Supply grains and goods to the people living on the fort.
- To arrange for the ammunition for the guns and firearms at the time of war.
- To look after and maintain the fort and the buildings on it.

Guns and Ammunition

At the time of Shivaji Maharaj, guns (cannons) of various sizes were used to protect the forts from the enemy. The guns were placed on the bastions and fortifications of the fort. Some forts like Purandar and Bhimgad had provisions for making guns. Guns were made from metals like iron, brass, copper, etc. In the rainy season, the guns were given a wax-coating to prevent rusting. Iron and stone cannonballs and canister shots were fired at the enemy from the guns. To fire the shots, an explosive mixture was used.

Discuss :

- The guns on the fort were given a coating of wax.

Can you tell?

- Name the types of the vessels in Shivaji Maharaj's navy, for example, *gurab*, *galbat*, *pal*, *machwa*, *nav*, *hodi* (boat).
- Name the ships in the Navy of Independent India.

The Navy

A navy consists of warships. The English, the Portuguese, the Siddis and the Dutch had a strong naval force. Some of these people used to plunder the villages

Shivaji Maharaj inspecting the navy

on the sea coast and torture the villagers. Shivaji Maharaj created an independent navy to permanently subdue these enemies on the sea.

Shivaji Maharaj raised several dockyards to build ships of various sizes. He gained control over old sea forts by winning them in battles. He repaired sea forts like Suvarnadurg and Vijaydurg. He built a new sea fort called Sindhudurg on the Kurte island near Malvan. He also built the fort of Khanderi near Mumbai.

The Swaraj navy included people belonging to various sea-faring communities like Koli, Bhandari, and Agari. Daulatkhan, Maynak Bhandari, Lai Patil, Daryasarang, Tukoji Angre were some of the great men of his period, skilled in naval warfare.

Because of the Maratha navy, the English, the Portuguese, the Siddis and the Dutch who were the enemies of the Marathas began to fear and respect them. Their nuisance to Swaraj was reduced. By raising an independent and strong navy, Shivaji Maharaj defined his territorial waters and established domination over the coastal area. He safeguarded his sea-coast. This navy was the first of its kind in medieval India. That is why he is rightly regarded as the 'Father of the Indian Navy'.

Intelligence Department : There was a well-organized and very efficient system of army intelligence and espionage. Bahirji Naik was the chief of this branch. The accurate information that he obtained helped greatly in making the campaigns like the Surat campaign successful. Shivaji's spies found out detailed information about the enemy camp. Shivaji Maharaj started no offensive unless he had gathered information from his spies. That is how he planned his campaigns.

Guerilla Tactics : In the defence strategy of Shivaji Maharaj, guerilla tactics were especially important. Guerilla tactics include sudden and unexpected attacks on the enemy at a strategic place and time. The guerilla army attacks the enemy, and without giving them time to recover, reaches a safe destination. Shivaji Maharaj was helped by the dense forests and hill forts in the Sahyadris and the support of his subjects in this guerilla warfare.

Do you know?

- Shivaji Maharaj had a disciplined army. His soldiers treated women with respect. Shivaji Maharaj, therefore, came to be known as the protector of women. He had strictly warned his soldiers not to drink alcohol, not to trouble his subjects and not to extort money from them.

Do you know?

- A few of the associates of Shivaji Maharaj – Kanhoji Jedhe, Veer Baji Pasalkar, Firangoji Narsala, Prataprao Gujar, Sidhoji Nimbalkar and Siddi Hilal.

Exercise

1. Can you tell these names?

(a) The book which tells us about the importance of forts ..... .

(b) Another name for sea forts ..... .

2. Write what you feel.

(a) Shivaji Maharaj is rightly called the 'Father of the Indian Navy'.

(b) Areas in which we can see Shivaji Maharaj's management skills.

3. Write two of the things that these officers did.

(a) Killedar 1. ..... 2. .....

(b) Sabnis 1. ..... 2. .....

(c) Karkhanis 1. ..... 2. .....

4. Show the following on an outline map of Maharashtra.

(a) Fort Sindhudurg (b) Vijaydurg

(c) Mumbai (d) Pratapgad

5. Which aspect of Shivaji Maharaj's management skills did you like the most? How will you use it in your daily routine?

Activity :

(a) Present a play in the classroom on the subject of 'An interview with Shivaji Maharaj'.

(b) Obtain information about the warships in the Indian Navy.

(c) Visit different types of forts and find out the names of the various places on it.

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